

explain why her party did so well in Singur and Nandigram she said it was because the people did not fall for CPI(M)'s propaganda that "*Krishi amader bhitti, shilpa amader bhabishat* (Agriculture is our base, industry is our future)."

The Congress, which maintains the number of Zilla Parishads where it is in power, also came out strongly against the Left Front. Says Congress leader Subrata Mukherjee, "The chief minister should resign following the mandate given in Singur and Nandigram."

The three-phase local body elections, which the chief minister had said would be a "people's festival" turned out to be a bloody battle not just between CPI(M) cadres and Trinamool and Congress supporters, but also between fellow Left Front members such as RSP and Forward Bloc.

The polls were also seen as a litmus test for the Bhattacharya Government's farmland acquisition policy for industries in the state. Never before had this debate of industrialisation versus agriculture played such a vital role in Panchayat elections. The results may

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OMINOUS: The results bode ill for Bhattacharya's push for reforms

come in the way of the party's efforts to push reforms in the Left-ruled states.

Top CPI(M) top leadership stood by the chief minister saying he never deviated ideologically. "After the experience of Nandigram, where a chemical hub was proposed to be set up and political and administrative mistakes were made, we must be all the more careful on large-scale land acquisition," CPI(M) noted in its recent assessment of the events at Nandigram.

After lying low following the Nandigram fiasco, Bhattacharya along with his reformist counterparts from the party's Kerala unit, had successfully pushed forward reform-friendly guidelines in the last party congress in April.

"We need to review the electoral results in Nandigram. People in Nandigram never wanted an SEZ there and we also failed to explain the project to the people before we started implementing it. The police firing also antagonised the common man," says M.K. Pandhe, CPI(M) Politburo member.

He also points at the alliance patched up by the Congress, Trinamool and BJP. "They had ideologically nothing in common. They are all bound by hate against CPI(M). We lost out not because our votes have gone down but because all-the anti-CPI(M) votes have been consolidated," says Pandhe.

The victory also brings cheer to civil society groups and the ultra-Left, whom the CPI(M) General Secretary Prakash Karat termed as Nardoniks, a dirty word in Marxist lexicon used to describe intellectuals who idealise agricultural economy. ■

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